THE LOWER MINNESOTA RIVER VALLEY · FIFTY YEARS, 1976–2026

# Minnesota Valley
## *National Wildlife Refuge*

◆

FORT SNELLING TO HENDERSON · MNI SOTA WAKPA

Established by Congress on October 8, 1976, Minnesota Valley National Wildlife Refuge is part of a corridor of land and water stretching nearly 70 miles along the Minnesota River (Mni Sota Wakpa), from Bloomington to Henderson. Its more than 15,000 acres of marsh, floodplain lake, bottomland forest, oak savanna and prairie give migrating waterfowl, bald eagles and songbirds a haven at the edge of the Twin Cities. The valley is Dakota homeland; Bdote, where the Minnesota and Mississippi rivers meet, is a place of deep significance to the Dakota Oyate.

MINNEAPOLIS
SAINT PAUL
WEST ST. PAUL
SOUTH ST. PAUL
EDINA
RICHFIELD
MENDOTA
MENDOTA HEIGHTS
Mississippi River
Bdote
where two waters come together
Pike Island
Historic Fort Snelling
Sibley Historic Site
Oheyawahi (Pilot Knob)
Minneapolis–St. Paul International Airport
Fort Snelling National Cemetery
Snelling Lake
Big Rivers Trail
Bloomington Education and Visitor Center
Gun Club Lake
Mall of America
Bass Ponds
LONG MEADOW LAKE UNIT
Long Meadow Lake
Fort Snelling State Park
Old Cedar Ave.
Jens Caspersen Landing
Minnesota River Greenway
Black Dog Lake
BLACK DOG LAKE UNIT
Lyndale Ave.
BLOOMINGTON
BLOOMINGTON FERRY UNIT
Bloomington Ferry
River Bottoms Trail
Minnesota River
Mni Sota Wakpa
Nine Mile Creek
INVER GROVE HEIGHTS
EAGAN
Fleming Field
Mississippi River
Wakpa Tanka
Moores Lake
Pine Bend Bluffs SNA
Baldwin Lake
Spring Lake
Lebanon Hills Regional Park
Minnesota Zoo
APPLE VALLEY
BURNSVILLE
ROSEMOUNT
DAKOTA COUNTY
COATES
Whitetail Woods Regional Park
Vermillion Highlands Research, Recreation and WMA
EMPIRE
Vermillion River
FARMINGTON
LAKEVILLE
Marion Lake
Orchard Lake
Crystal Lake
Murphy-Hanrehan Park Reserve
CREDIT RIVER
Credit River
SAVAGE
Savage Fen Scientific and Natural Area
Eagle Creek
WILKIE UNIT
Rice Lake
Fisher Lake
Wilkie
Blue Lake
Valleyfair
The Landing
Canterbury Park
UPGRALA UNIT
Rice Lake
Grass Lake
Flying Cloud Airport
Purgatory Creek
Riley Creek
Lake Riley
Staring Lake
Bush Lake
Hyland-Bush-Anderson Lakes Park Reserve
Bryant Lake
EDEN PRAIRIE
HENNEPIN COUNTY
Lotus Lake
Christmas Lake
CHANHASSEN
Minnesota Landscape Arboretum
Lake Minnetonka
Lake Minnewashta Regional Park
Lake Minnewashta
Lake Zumbra
Carver Park Reserve
Parley Lake
VICTORIA
Lake Auburn
Stieger Lake
Wassermann Lake
Lake Bavaria
Piersons Lake
Hazeltine Lake
Seminary Fen SNA
CHASKA
Minnesota Valley State Recreation Area
SHAKOPEE
Deans Lake
Lake Waconia
WACONIA
CARVER COUNTY
Miller Lake
Rice Lake
Tiger Lake
Barnes Lake
McLEOD COUNTY
PLATO
NORWOOD YOUNG AMERICA
COLOGNE
HAMBURG
Maria Lake
CARVER
Little Rapids historical marker
CHASKA UNIT
Carver Creek
RAPIDS LAKE UNIT
North Hunter Lot
Rapids Lake
Carver Rapids
Rapids Lake Education and Visitor Center
Renaissance Festival
Louisville Swamp
Jabs Farm
LOUISVILLE SWAMP UNIT
SAN FRANCISCO UNIT
Sand Creek
Bevens Creek
Minnesota Valley State Trail
Minnesota Valley State Recreation Area
SHAKOPEE MDEWAKANTON SIOUX COMMUNITY
O'Dowd Lake
Mystic Lake Casino
Lower Prior Lake
Upper Prior Lake
PRIOR LAKE
Spring Lake Regional Park
Spring Lake
Cleary Lake
Cleary Lake Regional Park
Geis Lake
JORDAN
SCOTT COUNTY
Fish Lake
ST. LAWRENCE UNIT
Curran Lake
GREEN ISLE
Erin Lake
Washington Lake
Schauer Lake
SIBLEY COUNTY
Silver Lake
ARLINGTON
Minnesota River
JESSENLAND UNIT
BELLE PLAINE
Robert Creek
High Island Creek
Ney WMA
BLAKELEY UNIT
Ney Nature Center
HENDERSON
Clark Lake
Pleasant Lake
Cedar Lake
Cedar Lake Farm Regional Park
NEW PRAGUE
Graham Lake
LE SUEUR COUNTY
494
35W
35E
35
62
100
77
110
55
13
52
56
3
149
50
212
5
7
41
101
169
282
21
19
25
284
CANADA
N.D.
MINNESOTA
MICH.
WIS.
S.D.
IOWA
ARDEN HILLS ARMY TRAINING SITE
Round Lake
ROUND LAKE UNIT
35W
10
694
N

## REFUGE UNITS

| | acres |
|---|---|
| Long Meadow Lake *Bloomington* | 2,403 |
| Black Dog Lake *Burnsville* | 1,500 |
| Bloomington Ferry *Bloomington* | 437 |
| Wilkie *Shakopee, Savage* | 2,037 |
| Upgrala *Eden Prairie, Chanhassen* | 419 |
| Chaska *Carver, Chaska* | 580 |
| Rapids Lake *Carver* | 2,203 |
| Louisville Swamp *Jordan, Shakopee* | 2,625 |
| San Francisco *Jordan, Carver* | 52 |
| St. Lawrence *Jordan, Belle Plaine* | 451 |
| Jessenland *Belle Plaine, Henderson* | 1,127 |
| Blakeley *Henderson* | 1,144 |
| Round Lake *Arden Hills (inset)* | 157 |
| **Total** | **15,135** |

*Includes fee-title, easement and cooperatively managed lands; acreages computed from USFWS unit data.*

## VISITOR CENTERS

**Bloomington Education and Visitor Center**
3815 American Blvd. East, Bloomington · 952-854-5900

**Rapids Lake Education and Visitor Center**
15865 Rapids Lake Road, Carver · 952-361-4500

**www.fws.gov/refuge/minnesota-valley**

## LOCATION

## ROUND LAKE UNIT, ARDEN HILLS

*About 13 miles north of Historic Fort Snelling · scale 1:21,000*

## LEGEND

- 🟩 Refuge land owned by USFWS (fee title)
- 🟩 Refuge easement or cooperative agreement
- Approved refuge acquisition boundary
- Valley floor, up to about 30 ft above the river
- River or lake
- Marsh or swamp
- Stream
- State park or recreation area
- Scientific and Natural Area or Wildlife Mgmt. Area
- Regional or county park
- Tribal land
- Airport grounds
- County boundary
- Refuge trail
- State trail
- Regional trail
- Interstate
- U.S. or state freeway
- U.S. or state highway
- County road
- Local road
- Railroad
- Visitor center
- Trailhead or parking
- Boat launch
- ▲ Historic site
- ● Point of interest
- Airport
- ○ City or town under 5,000 people
- 35W 169 13 Interstate, U.S. and state routes

*Scale 1:42,000 at 84 × 42 in · 1 inch = about 0.66 mile (use the bars at other sizes)*

0 1 2 3 4 5 miles

0 2 4 6 8 kilometers

N

Shaded relief from USGS 3DEP 10-meter elevation. The north arrow points to grid north, within 1 degree of true north on this map. UTM projection, zone 15 north, North American Datum of 1983.

Data sources. U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service: refuge units and land status, approved acquisition boundary, trails and facilities (FWS cadastral and refuge facilities data, 2020–2026); unit acreages are computed from these data. U.S. Geological Survey: 3D Elevation Program 1/3 arc-second elevation (relief shading and valley-floor tint), National Hydrography Dataset, Geographic Names Information System. U.S. Census Bureau: TIGER/Line Shapefiles 2025 (roads, rail, boundaries, cities, tribal lands, river surfaces), 2025 cartographic boundary files, Vintage 2025 population estimates. Minnesota Department of Natural Resources via the Minnesota Geospatial Commons: state parks, Scientific and Natural Areas, Wildlife Management Areas, state trails, lakes and wetlands. Metropolitan Council: regional parks, regional trails, airport boundaries. Minnesota Department of Transportation: airport runways. Dakota place names (Bdote, Mni Sota Wakpa, Wakpa Tanka, Oheyawahi): Minnesota Historical Society and National Park Service.

Boundaries are approximate and for general reference only. This is not an official U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service publication; check with the refuge for current regulations, trail conditions and seasonal closures. Map compiled October 2026.

## FIFTY YEARS ON THE RIVER · 1976–2026

### 1976
Congress establishes the refuge on October 8 (Public Law 94-466), authorizing an initial purchase of 9,500 acres.

### 1984
A conservation plan is completed with the State of Minnesota and local partners; the Act is amended to allow 2,000 more acres.

### 1995
The Mittelstad tract, today's Rapids Lake Unit, is added, bringing the refuge to nearly 14,000 acres.

### 2020
The refuge is designated an urban wildlife refuge and awarded $1 million to strengthen urban programs.

### 2026
The refuge marks 50 years with anniversary events. More than 45 miles of trails are open daily, 5 a.m. to 10 p.m., free of charge.